

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Eastertide 6

Resisting with Joy ~ Gratitude & Generosity

17 May 2026



Photo by Ian Cumming

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on HYFRYDOL and LOBE DEN HERREN

Selections from Musical Theater:

Maybe from *Annie* (Charles Strouse and Martin Charnin)

Someone To Watch Over Me from *Oh Kay!* (George and Ira Gershwin)

Day By Day from *Godspell* (Stephen Schwartz)

Everything's Alright from *Jesus Christ Superstar* (Andrew Lloyd Webber and Tim Rice)

It Ain't Necessarily So from *Porgy And Bess* (George and Ira Gershwin)

You'll Never Walk Alone from *Carousel* (Rodgers & Hammerstein)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Gabriella Walls & Rev. Lehman

There is but one place and time
where joy can be found:
here, and now...

If we don't have it now,
where we are,
chances are not good
that we will find it later,
somewhere else.

It has less to do with
surroundings and companions
and more to do with the attitude
and outlook we have
about and for ourselves.

When it is grounded in these three –
here, now, and self – no one
can steal it from us.

This morning, let us decide
that we will not waste one more moment
of our lives
searching for joy.
Instead, we will embrace
the joy in all that we have
in this time and place.

[mtirabassi/lf]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

God, Whose Giving Knows No Ending

HYFRYDOL

God, whose giving knows no ending, from your rich and endless store,
Nature's wonder, Jesus' wisdom, costly cross, grave's shattered door:
Gifted by you, we turn to you offering up ourselves in praise;
Thankful song shall rise forever, gracious donor of our days.

Skills and time are ours for serving, that your will on earth be done:
All at peace in health and freedom, races joined, the Church made one.
Now direct our daily labor lest we strive for self alone;
Born with talents, make us a people fit to answer on our own.

Treasure, too, you have entrusted, gain through powers your grace conferred;
Ours to use for home and kindred, and to spread the gospel's words.
Open wide our hands in sharing as we heed your ageless call,
Healing, teaching, and reclaiming, honoring you by loving all.

Lend your joy to all our giving, let it light our journey's way;
From the night of anxious keeping, loose us into generous day.
Then when years on earth are over, and we've lived our human span,
God, fulfill beyond our dreaming, all our stewardship began.

Prayer of Awareness

Rev. Lehman

Holy One,
everywhere we turn, everyplace we look,
in each intake of breath
and in every word exhaled,
we dwell in possibility.

What we see, what we hear,
what we taste and smell and touch --
all these realities intermingle with the mystery
of what will be.

Help us, O God, to move towards that which
is most precious to us and,
through our connectedness,
let us be transformed, reworked, rejuvenated.

*In your endless flow,
let us gratefully and generously become your life here on earth.
We pray this as those who follow the Way.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

Westminster Chimes, as heard in *Mary Poppins*
Cathedral Ringers, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Director*

DOUGLAS E. WAGNER

***The Lord's Prayer**

Gabriella Walls

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.
Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people
This day, tonight, and forever.*

John Philip Newell

Amen and Amen!

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

Gratitude unlocks the fullness of life.
It turns what we have into enough, and more.
It turns denial into acceptance,
chaos to order,
confusion to clarity.

It can turn a meal into a feast,
a house into a home,
a stranger into a friend.

Gratitude makes sense of our past, brings peace for today,
and creates a vision for tomorrow.

[Melody Beattie]

May the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition

Gabriella Walls

from the Gospel of Luke, chapter 24

While they were talking about this, Jesus himself stood among them and said to them, "Peace be with you." They were startled and terrified and thought that they were seeing a ghost. He said to them, "Why are you frightened, and why do doubts arise in your hearts? Look at my hands and my feet; see that it is I myself. Touch me and see, for a ghost does not have flesh and bones as you see that I have." And when he had said this, he showed them his hands and his feet. Yet for all

their joy they were still disbelieving and wondering, and he said to them, "Have you anything here to eat?" They gave him a piece of broiled fish, and he took it and ate in their presence.

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace...

Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

For the wisdom you reveal to us,
For the truth you show to us,
For the way you came to us,
Became one of us, yet so much more than us:

We are so grateful.

For the expanding grandeur of Creation,
Worlds known and unknown,
Galaxies beyond galaxies,
Filling us with awe and challenging our imaginations:

We are so grateful.

For this fragile planet earth,
Its times and tides, its sunsets and seasons:

We are so grateful.

For the joy of human life,
Its wonders and surprises,
its hopes and achievements:

We are so grateful.

For this community,
Our common past and future hope,
Our oneness transcending all separation,
Our capacity to work for peace and justice in the midst of
apathy:

We are so grateful.

For high hopes and noble causes,
For faith without fanaticism,
For understanding of views not shared:

We are so grateful.

For all who have labored and suffered for a fairer world,
Who have lived so that others might live in dignity
and freedom:

We are so grateful.

May we live not imprisoned by our fears,
but released by your hope,
May we live not by our words or by our deeds
But by your truth which is too vast to hold,
May we live not by the level of understanding
Or in our own wisdom,
But by the power of the life we co-create with you.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen!

Meditation Anthem

MILTON YAGER & JACK YELLEN

Happy Days Are Here Again/ Hallelujah Come on Get Happy, from *Chasing Rainbows*
Christin Byrdsong and Ianthe Marini, *Duet*, Christoph Bull, *Piano*

Sermon

Rev. Michael Lehman

Gratitude & Generosity ~ Fortunate to Be Alive & Filled with Joy

Invitation to Generosity

Gabriella Walls

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

May we look with gratitude upon this day,
for the beauty of the world,
or the first radiance of dawn
and the last smoldering glow of sunset.

Let us be thankful for physical joys,
for hills to climb and hard work to do,
for music that lifts our hearts in one breath,
for the hand-clasp of a friend,
and for the gracious loveliness of children
who remind us of the wonders of life.

May we be appreciative above all
for the concern and love of those around us,
for the exceeding bliss of the touch of the holy,
which suddenly awakens our drowsy souls
to the blessed awareness of the divine
within us and within others.

For all of this,
and for the countless other blessings present in our lives,
we are grateful.

[Gratitude by Michael R Leduc]

Offertory

Make Them Hear You, from *Ragtime* LYNN AHRENS & STEPHEN FLAHERTY

Cathedral Choir, Christin Byrdsong, Frank Hobbs, Chohi Kim, *Trio*, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Gabriella Walls

For your goodness, O God, boundless and everlasting,
for your generosity, gracious and wise,
for your mercy, strong and free,
thanks be to you.

With these offerings, may we practice your generosity,
share your goodness,
and live your mercy so that we and our world
may be well.

May it be so, O God.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

We shall this day sow grace and peace,
and show mercy to all,
and gentle loving-kindness.
And we shall not think only
of ourselves and our needs,
but we shall become
a constant source of giving.

Bless us, O God.
All of us.
Every one of us.
Every part of us.

Bless us, O God.
This day,
and forever more.
Amen and Amen!

Choral Response

Somewhere, from *West Side Story* LEONARD BERNSTEIN &
Laude, Molly Pease & Katelyn Dietz, *Duet*, Dr. Ianthe Marini, Assistant Director STEPHEN SONDEHEIM

***Hymn for the Journey**

Sing Praise

LOBE DEN HERREN

Sing praise to all that has offered us life and sustains us –
All that has opened our hearts to the love borne within us:
Family and friends, beauty we see without end –
Gifts that our lives lay before us.

Sing praise to all that has opened our minds to new vistas –
All that has called us to seek out new truths through the ages:
Vision and word, music that sought to be heard
These are the gifts that will mold us.

Sing praise to minds that will fashion our bold new tomorrows –
Yesterday's wisdom released from its dogma and credos.
Evermore free to live out what we believe
Walking the path that life hallows.

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Do You Hear the People Sing, from *Les Misérables* Claude-Michel Schönberg & Alain Boublil
Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*, Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

Inside The Music

Dr. Ianthe Marini

Musical Theatre has a limitless capacity to help us explore, experience, and exercise our emotional life in a way that ensures and comforts us in the knowledge that we are never alone! The music of the musical theatre tradition boldly, beautifully, bravely, and brashly illustrates our theme "*Gratitude and Generosity and the Fortune to Be Alive and Filled with Joy*". With sweeping melodies, lush harmonies that breathe tension and release, a rhythmic language that often expresses yearning, desperation, and want, and a vocal technique traditionally using full capacity of the voice and breath, musical theatre meets us at our biggest and highest emotions and tells us that Big Feelings are never too big, and never too much! Theatre offers us an opportunity to understand and recognize our own truths by seeing them illuminated by the truths of another on stage. Theatre ignites a fire within us, helps us experience catharsis, bolsters our courage to raise our voices with others in the pursuit and fight for freedom and equality, and helps us live into the gratitude of what it means to be alive!

Our music today spans a full century of this tradition. We begin with a beckoning call to our senses with the bell choir through *Westminster Chimes*, made popular through *Mary Poppins*: a melody that likely evokes and sparks our memory. We then hear the Yager & Yeller duet *Happy Days are here again / hallelujah come on get happy* from the musical *Chasing Rainbows*, popularized by the 1932 presidential run of FDR and often associated with the desperate optimism and actualized NEED for HOPE in the New Deal Era. This is not a song of toxic positivity, rather, an expression of communal grit and resilience in the throes of social depression — an arrangement and agreement, *a new deal* made that together we can bring about the change that make Joy and Hope verbs! In this vein, in offertory we sing *Make Them Hear You* from *Ragtime*, a musical illustrating the interrelationships of three racial groups in turn-of-the-20th-century New York City: the comforts, privileges, and affluence of White Anglo-Saxon Protestants in New Rochelle, the harsh living realities of the Lower East Side meeting immigrants from eastern and western Europe, and the racism, police brutality, and injustices faced by Black Americans in Harlem. The song is an anthem and a rallying cry in the musical theatre repertoire, encouraging us to

find our voices together in the fight for freedom and equity. We end with that great hopeful wish from *West Side Story* — that there IS a place for us, a time and place for us, to live, to love, to learn, to be. *Hold my hand and we're halfway there—hold my hand and I'll take you there. Somehow. Someday. Somewhere. And finally: TOMORROW COMES!*

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